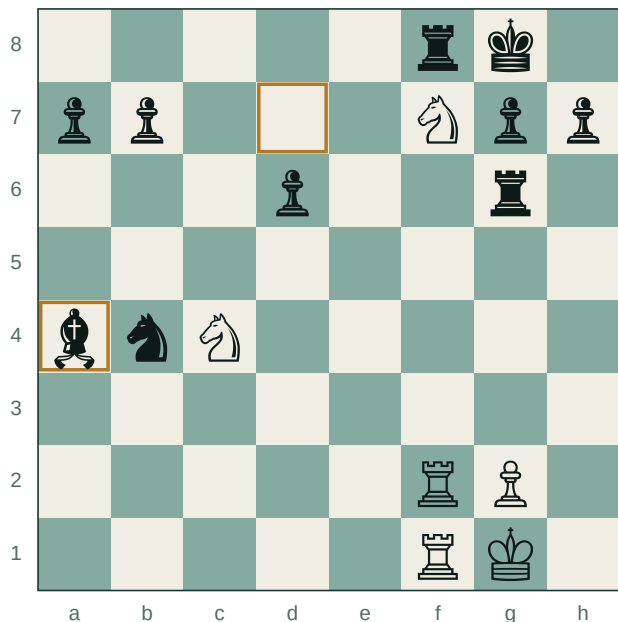


Mate in three: White, move 27

Mate in three

White to move



Previous move: 26...Bxa4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

27. Nh6+ gxh6 28. Rxf8+ Kg7 29. R1f7#

27.Nh6+ Check restricts Black to 3 legal replies here. The changed line means the rook on f2 attacks the rook on f8. Recorded reply: **27...gxh6**.

28.Rxf8+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the rook on f8. Recorded reply: **28...Kg7**.

29.R1f7# Mate: rook on f7 gives check; Black has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on g7. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Rook on f7. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not stop at a promising check. The final mating position must still be legal after every intervening move.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Longer mating lines require accurate visualization. Track the king's square, opened lines, and every sacrificed piece through the entire sequence.

HOW TO LOOK

Work backward from a mating pattern, then calculate forward with the opponent choosing the strongest defense.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: knight on b4 and bishop on a4. Check for tactical protection.